the wedding might well be considered null and void if a priest didn't turn up to conduct it.

Given this dislike of priestly intermediaries in my gene pool, it is no wonder that as a young boy I asked my father why it was necessary to go to temples. If God is everywhere, I reasoned, isn't He (or She) at home, at school, at work? Why do we need to go to a temple to find Her? My father patiently explained that while God is everywhere, He was especially powerful in certain places, especially those where He had manifested himself through the spontaneous appearance of an idol (as in the Krishna idol in Guruvayur) or other miracles. Such places then became sanctified by the devotions of millions of worshippers over hundreds of years, and thus acquired even more religious significance. It was a self-perpetuating phenomenon: a temple became famous because of something associated with it, usually a legend involving the deity in question, then worshippers came and testified to its powers, saying their prayers at that place had been answered by the Goddess, for instance, and then more worshippers came and the more devotion the temple attracted, the more were the stories of miracles and blessings accruing from worship there, and the more people kept coming….

On that south Indian pilgrimage when I was fourteen, I also found myself asking my father about the behaviour of some of the priests at the more famous temples, who openly stuck out their hands for more money after performing the rituals my father had already paid for. He looked somewhat embarrassed at first, then replied softly but firmly that priests had to live too. They were performing a service to us devotees, but they had families they were responsible for, children they had to educate, and it was only fair they asked for help from the people on whose behalf they had interceded with God. After all, they had what today we would call 'domain knowledge'; they knew the scriptures, had mastered the mantras and could recite the appropriate ones with the required fluency. Why shouldn't they be rewarded for their expertise?

This left my teenage mind only partly mollified, and I have not been as enthusiastic a temple-goer as my parents, especially since I rationalised that praying in the privacy of my own home would be just as effective, as long as my heart was pure and my thoughts clear. I maintain